

LOST PROPERTY

Written by

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Self-written sample screenplay for Panelwise.
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FADE IN:

EXT. PARK STATION - NIGHT

Rain sheets down on a grand old railway station. Its clock tower reads ten to eleven. A last taxi pulls away, wipers beating.

Under the arches, a hand-painted sign: LOST PROPERTY - PLATFORM 9.

INT. LOST PROPERTY OFFICE - NIGHT

A long narrow room lined floor to ceiling with shelves. Umbrellas in a barrel. A tin bath full of single shoes. A rocking horse with one ear. Somewhere, a clock ticks.

ZANELE (30s), cardigan over her railway uniform, sits behind a wooden counter writing in a fat green LEDGER. Beside her elbow, a brass BELL.

A ginger cat, MARMALADE, sleeps on a pile of lost scarves.

MR. DUBE (60s), the station master, waistcoat and pocket watch, backs through the door carrying a box tied with string.

MR. DUBE

Forty-one years, Zanele. Forty-one years I have walked these platforms, and tonight is my last night shift.

ZANELE

You say that as if you're sad about it.

MR. DUBE

(setting the box down)

I am sad about it. Who will wind the tower clock? Who will chase the pigeons out of the waiting room?

ZANELE

Me, probably.

He peers at the ledger over his spectacles.

MR. DUBE

What came in today?

ZANELE

(reading)

Three umbrellas. One wedding hat. A set of false teeth, which I have put in a jar. And a birthday cake, uneaten.

MR. DUBE

Whose birthday?

ZANELE

It didn't say.

INT. STATION CONCOURSE - CONTINUOUS

A vast hall of marble and iron. Almost empty. A SLEEPING COMMUTER lies across a bench under a newspaper.

PRIYA (20), soaked through, a music satchel over one shoulder, runs across the concourse, looking everywhere at once.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

The last train to Pretoria has now departed from platform four. There are no further departures tonight.

Priya stops dead under the departures board. Every line reads CANCELLED or DEPARTED.

PRIYA

(under her breath)

No. No, no, no.

She spots the hand-painted sign for Lost Property and runs.

INT. LOST PROPERTY OFFICE - MOMENTS LATER

The door flies open. The brass bell on the counter jumps. Marmalade opens one eye.

PRIYA

My violin. I left my violin on the train from Soweto. A black case with a red ribbon on the handle. Please tell me somebody handed it in.

ZANELE

(opening the ledger)

Which train?

PRIYA

The nine-fifteen. I fell asleep.
When I woke up I was at the end of
the line and the case was gone.

Zanele runs her finger down the page, slowly.

ZANELE

Umbrella. Umbrella. Hat. Teeth.
Cake. I'm sorry. No violin.

PRIYA

It has to be here. My audition is
at eight tomorrow morning. It was
my grandfather's violin. There is
no other one.

Mr. Dube takes off his cap.

MR. DUBE

Sit down, young lady. Nothing is
lost at Park Station until I say
so.

He lifts the brass bell and rings it, twice. Loud.

INT. PLATFORM NINE - NIGHT

A long covered platform, lit by humming lamps. Rain drums on
the iron roof.

KOOS (70s), the night cleaner, pushes a wide broom along the
platform edge. He wears headphones over a woolly hat and
hums to himself.

At the far end, TEBOGO (20s), a busker in a patched denim
jacket, plays a VIOLIN. A black case lies open at his feet
with a few coins in it. A red ribbon is tied to its handle.

The music is beautiful. Koos stops sweeping to listen.

KOOS

That's a sad one.

TEBOGO

(still playing)

It's a sad instrument. I think it
misses somebody.

Two police officers walk onto the platform: OFFICER MOLOI
(40s), broad and patient, and OFFICER VAN WYK (20s), new,
eager, notebook already out.

OFFICER VAN WYK
(whispering)
Sarge. Black case. Red ribbon.

OFFICER MOLOI
I have eyes, Van Wyk.

INT. LOST PROPERTY OFFICE - LATER

Priya sits on a folding chair with a mug of tea she hasn't touched. Mr. Dube is on the office telephone, a heavy black thing with a curly cord.

MR. DUBE
(into phone)
Yes, the nine-fifteen. Yes, a violin. Thank you, Tshepo. You are a good man.

He hangs up.

The door opens again. GRACE (30s), a nurse still in her scrubs, comes in holding the hand of AMAHLE (8), who is wearing pyjamas under a yellow raincoat and has clearly been crying.

GRACE
I'm sorry to come so late. We lost a giraffe.

ZANELE
A giraffe.

AMAHLE
A toy one. His name is Gerald. He has a blue scarf and one of his legs is shorter than the others.

ZANELE
(gently)
When did you last see Gerald?

AMAHLE
On the escalator. I was holding him up so he could see the pigeons, and then he wasn't there any more.

Zanele writes it carefully in the ledger.

ZANELE
Giraffe. Gerald. Blue scarf. One short leg.

A knock on the open door. SAM (20s), a bicycle courier in a dripping rain cape, holds up a clipboard.

SAM
Delivery for a Mr. Dube? I was told
to bring it here at eleven exactly.

Sam hands over a flat white box. Mr. Dube frowns at it.

MR. DUBE
I didn't order anything.

SAM
It's paid for. Sign here, please.

He signs. Sam salutes with the clipboard and is gone.

INT. PLATFORM NINE - CONTINUOUS

Tebogo finishes the tune and lowers the violin. The two officers stand in front of him.

OFFICER MOLOI
Evening. That's a fine instrument.

TEBOGO
It isn't mine.

OFFICER VAN WYK
(scribbling)
Suspect admits instrument is not
his.

OFFICER MOLOI
Van Wyk.

TEBOGO
I found it on the nine-fifteen,
under a seat. I was going to take
it to Lost Property, but the office
light was off when I passed, and
then it started raining, and then
--

(beat)
I thought if I played it, whoever
lost it might hear.

KOOS
He's been playing for an hour.
Nobody came.

OFFICER MOLOI
Somebody might have. Pack it up,
son. We're going for a walk.

INT. STATION CONCOURSE - LATER

Priya stands at the concourse railing with Zanele. The sleeping commuter snores under his newspaper.

Faintly, from far away, violin music echoes off the marble. Then it stops.

PRIYA
Did you hear that?

ZANELE
Hear what?

PRIYA
That was my grandfather's tune. I
would know it anywhere. Nobody else
plays it.

She is already running toward the platforms.

ZANELE
Priya, wait!

INT. LOST PROPERTY OFFICE - NIGHT

Officer Moloi steers Tebogo through the door, the violin case under his arm. Officer Van Wyk follows. Then Priya, out of breath. Then Zanele.

Everyone is suddenly in the small room at once. Marmalade leaves in disgust.

PRIYA
That's it. That's my case.

OFFICER VAN WYK
We found the suspect playing it on
platform nine.

TEBOGO
I'm not a suspect. I'm a musician.

OFFICER MOLOI
He says he found it on the nine-
fifteen.

Priya opens the case. Inside the lid, a faded photograph of an old man holding the same violin.

PRIYA
(quietly)
It's here. It's all here.

She turns to Tebogo.

PRIYA
You played his tune. How do you
know his tune?

TEBOGO
I didn't. The music was folded in
the case. I just read it.

A long moment. Then Priya laughs, and cries a little, and
laughs again.

MR. DUBE
Officers, I believe this is a case
of lost property, and lost property
is my department.

OFFICER MOLOI
(closing his notebook)
Then we'll leave it with you, Mr.
Dube.

OFFICER VAN WYK
But Sarge, the paperwork --

OFFICER MOLOI
Van Wyk.

The officers leave. Amahle tugs at her mother's scrubs.

AMAHLE
Mama, what about Gerald?

INT. CONCOURSE RAFTERS - NIGHT

High above the concourse, among iron beams and pigeons, Koos
climbs a tall wooden LADDER with a torch in his teeth.

He reaches into a nest of twigs and newspaper and pulls out
a small toy GIRAFFE in a blue scarf.

A pigeon glares at him.

KOOS
Sorry, my friend. He's already got
a home.

INT. LOST PROPERTY OFFICE - LATER

Koos comes in with the giraffe held up high like a trophy.

KOOS
Is anybody missing a Gerald?

Amahle shrieks and hugs the giraffe so hard his short leg sticks straight out.

AMAHLE

Gerald! You went to see the pigeons without me!

GRACE

Thank you. Thank you, all of you.

Mr. Dube unties the string on the white box. Inside is a cake, iced with the words HAPPY RETIREMENT MR. DUBE - FROM PLATFORM 9.

MR. DUBE

Who did this?

ZANELE

(shrugging)

Lost property. Nobody claimed it.

Mr. Dube looks at the cake for a long moment. He takes out his handkerchief and blows his nose, loudly.

MR. DUBE

Well. Someone find me a knife. And plates. And Tebogo, if you would play something that isn't sad.

Tebogo looks at Priya. She hands him the violin.

PRIYA

Just one song. Then I need it back. I have somewhere to be at eight.

Tebogo plays something bright and quick. Amahle dances with Gerald. Koos taps his broom. Even Marmalade comes back to the doorway to watch.

EXT. PLATFORM FOUR - DAWN

The rain has stopped. Pale gold light slides along the rails. The first train of the day sighs to a stop.

Priya steps aboard with the violin case held tight against her chest. At the window she waves.

On the platform, Tebogo raises his hand. Beside him, Mr. Dube winds his pocket watch one last time and looks up at the station clock.

MR. DUBE

Right on time.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)
The six-oh-five to Pretoria is now
departing from platform four.

The train pulls away into the morning.

FADE OUT.